

STRAIT OF HORMUZ CRISIS REPORT

OPERATION EPIC FURY // MULTI-SOURCE INTELLIGENCE SYNTHESIS

REPORT DATE	CLASSIFICATION	SOURCE TIER	FRAMEWORK
29 MAR 2026	OPEN SOURCE	T1 / T2 / T3	CLUSTER Z // ATLAS

01 GROUND SITUATION — STRIPPED OF WESTERN FRAMING

CONFIRMED

Western consensus frames Iran as retaliating for a US-Israel strike and resisting efforts to reopen the strait. The raw signal is significantly more complex.

CONFIRMED TIMELINE

- Feb 28, 2026 — US and Israeli strikes kill Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei.
- Mar 2 — IRGC officially declares the Strait closed as standing policy, not a temporary measure. 21+ confirmed IRGC attacks on merchant vessels within the first two weeks.
- Mar 2 — IRGC strikes the US Fifth Fleet HQ at Mina Selman port, Bahrain — 95% (Makran Sea Blog, Persian maritime sources).
two waves, missiles and drones. Ship traffic through Hormuz collapses
- Mar 9 — New Mojtaba (Ali's son) installed by Assembly of Experts under "The Strait of Hormuz
Supreme Leader Khamenei documented IRGC pressure. First statement: must remain closed."
- Late Mar — toll booth : \$2M USD per transit, payable in Chinese yuan or USDT through IRGC-linked
IRGC regime via intermediaries. India and Pakistan receive diplomatic passage waivers.
formalizes a Larak Island 350+ tankers stranded.
- Mar 19 — US Operation Epic : A-10 Warthogs and AH-64 Apaches deployed to hunt IRGC fast-attack
launches Fury boats and intercept drones.
- Mar 26 — IRGC Navy Commander Alireza Tangsiri killed in Israeli airstrike.
- Mar 29 Houthis activate a , threatening Bab el-Mandeb. Pentagon reportedly planning a limited
(Today) — new front ground operation on Iranian territory.

02 NARRATIVE DIVERGENCE MAP

CRITICAL GAP

DIVERGENCE 1 — THE SUCCESSION STORY

English media frames Iran as "continuing its fight." The actual Farsi-language signal indicates a regime-level rupture that Western reporting is treating as a footnote.

- Farsi sources (Iran International, NCRI, IranTC) banned — calling it a violation of the 1979
report that Ali Khamenei's own advisors presented hereditary Revolution's founding anti-
evidence he had explicitly succession monarchical principle.
- Iran International: IRGC "repeated contacts and psychological and on Assembly of Experts members
commanders applied political pressure" to elect Mojtaba.
- Mojtaba is a mid-level cleric with no published Velayat- by any traditional clerical standard.
scholarly work — he does not meet the e faqih Former presidents Khatami and Rouhani
jurisprudential requirements of openly opposed him.

Bottom line: The IRGC has effectively seized control of the Iranian state. Mojtaba is a clerical veneer over what is functionally an IRGC junta. The regime's founding legitimacy claim was violated in real time. This is arguably the most significant internal rupture in the Islamic Republic's history.

- Farsi diaspora press and Wikipedia's 2025–2026 Iranian protests entry describe what is reportedly the

largest protest movement since the 1979 Revolution

– spreading across 200+ cities. Crackdowns have produced what analysts call "the largest massacres in modern Iranian history."
- Simultaneous pressures: 20,000 sailors stranded on 3,000 ships, food prices up

40–120% , economy contracting 10%. Iran is fighting an external war and an internal revolt while managing a legitimacy-deficient succession.

The simultaneity is the signal.

DIVERGENCE 3 — THE TOLL BOOTH AS GEOPOLITICAL ARCHITECTURE

Western framing: Iran is "partly reopening" the strait as a tactical concession.
Farsi sources: It is a victory – and a new economic order.

- Fararu headline translates as:

"The strait is open – but only for those who pay the toll!"

– framed internally as a victory, not a retreat.
- Parliament Speaker Qalibaf (snn.ir):

"The reopening of Hormuz has become Trump's 'operational dream' – it hasn't happened."

He then explicitly linked domestic protest suppression, missile capability, and Hormuz as

three concurrent pressure levers .

Iran is not retreating. It is institutionalizing the closure as revenue-generating leverage while selectively granting diplomatic passage to BRICS-adjacent partners. This is a bifurcated maritime economy being built in real time – Western shipping cut off, non-Western shipping pays or is comped.

03 EMERGENT TREND DETECTION

4 ACTIVE TRENDS

TREND A // ESCALATION NODE

CONFIRMED

Kharg Island — The Next Flashpoint

Trump has publicly discussed a ground assault on Kharg (90% of Iran's oil export capacity). CNN Arabic (Mar 26) reports Iran actively fortifying Kharg defenses. Iranian military commentary asserts Iranian forces could destroy US troops on Kharg "within 2 hours." Melliun.org notes the Southern Island Arc is treated as more strategically vital. A US ground seizure of Kharg would directly assault Iran's economic jugular – potentially triggering Bab el-Mandeb activation.

TREND B // DOUBLE CHOKEPOINT

CONFIRMED — BREAKING

Bab el-Mandeb Activation

Al Jazeera, CNN, CBS – all confirmed March 29: Houthis open a new front. An unnamed Iranian official stated Iran could activate Bab el-Mandeb if attacked on its territory or islands. Combined with Hormuz, this would represent the largest simultaneous maritime energy disruption in recorded history. 6–7M barrels/day transit Bab el-Mandeb. Full blockade has not yet been imposed, but the activation language is live.

TREND C // FINANCIAL ARCHITECTURE

PROBABLE

IRGC Toll Booth as Sanctions Bypass

\$2M per transit in yuan/USDT through IRGC-connected intermediaries. At 5 transits/week this generates \$40–50M/month flowing directly to IRGC-controlled accounts in non-Western currency, insulated from SWIFT. BNN Bloomberg and Foreign Policy have noted the mechanism but have not followed the architecture downstream. This is a sanctions-evasion financial engine being constructed under cover of a military crisis.

TREND D // DIPLOMATIC MANEUVER

EMERGING

Pakistan's Expanding Footprint

Pakistan's Foreign Minister confirmed Iran granted 20 Pakistani-flagged ships exemption (~2/day). Shafaqna (Persian/Arabic) covered extensively. Pakistan is inserting itself as diplomatic broker between Iran and the global shipping community – extracting leverage from both sides. Consistent with Pakistan's historic pattern of exploiting US-Iran tensions for regional positioning. Watch for Islamabad to monetize this role with Washington.

04 POWER & LEVERAGE DYNAMICS

ANALYSIS

▲ GAINING MECHANISM

IRGC	Pressured the succession, runs the toll booth, controls the military front, and now effectively controls the Supreme Leader's office. Iran has become a military state with a clerical façade.
China	Toll collected in yuan. China's currency is being institutionalized as the settlement medium for a global strategic chokepoint. Zero English outlets have focused on this.
India / Pakistan	Both extracted diplomatic passage exemptions. India's energy security preserved through bilateral channels outside Western-led architecture. Pakistan gains prestige and regional leverage.

▼ LOSING	MECHANISM
Iranian Civilians	Paradoxically harmed most by the closure their government executed. Food imports via Hormuz disrupted. 93 million people facing 40–120% food price spikes.
Gulf Arab States	IRGC warned shipping "to and from ports of allies of the enemies." Saudi Arabia, UAE, Qatar all implicated – energy exports constrained. None publicly stating this.
Islamic Republic's Ideological Legitimacy	The Mojtaba succession was, in the words of critics, the moment the revolution became a dynasty. Long-burn destabilizer.
SECONDARY ACTORS — IGNORED BY WESTERN COVERAGE	
▶ Oman	– Not mentioned in any major English piece. Geographically and historically the natural mediator. Quiet diplomacy almost certainly active and invisible. Its silence is the signal.
▶ Turkey	– Identified in Farsi sources as receiving passage negotiation status alongside India and Pakistan. Role as passage broker is receiving zero English coverage.
▶ Assembly of Experts Dissenters	– Documented internal dissent within Iran's theological governance structure. Resisted IRGC pressure during succession vote. Almost no outside amplification.

05	GROUND TRUTH SIGNALS	HIGH PRIORITY
IRANIAN CIVILIAN SIGNAL		
The 2025–2026 Iranian protests are being systematically underreported in Western coverage of the war. The regime is fighting two wars simultaneously: external (US-Israel-Gulf) and internal (civilian revolt).		
▶ Parliament Speaker Qalibaf's Farsi statement explicitly references the streets:	"Don't leave the streets – missiles, streets, and the strait are squeezing the enemy's throat."	He is calling hardliners to hold public space – implying the regime fears it is being challenged.
MARITIME LABOR CRISIS		
▶ Payam Javan (Persian diaspora press) reports	20,000 sailors stranded on 3,000+ ships	in the Persian Gulf – unable to resupply, rotate, or in some cases communicate. This is a humanitarian crisis with near-zero English-language coverage.
MOJTABA HAS NOT APPEARED PUBLICLY		
▶ CNN (Mar 14):	"Iran's new supreme leader has yet to appear, and the system may not need him to."	A new Supreme Leader who took power under duress during an existential war has not appeared in public in 3+ weeks. Either being protected as an asset – or managed/controlled. The IRGC-as-junta hypothesis is strengthened by his absence.

06	FARSI REGISTER — CRITICAL TRANSLATION NOTES	LINGUISTIC INTEL
English translations systematically soften Iranian political-religious register. The actual semantic weight of key phrases carries strategic information that is being lost in translation.		
SOURCE: Rokna.net — Mojtaba Khamenei First Statement		
تنگه هرمز باید همچنان بسته بماند		
Literal: "The Strait of Hormuz MUST still remain closed."		
△ The word بایَد (bāyad) = religious obligation. In Farsi political-religious register from a Supreme Leader, this carries fatwa-adjacent weight. English translations render it as "should remain closed" – that softens the register significantly.		
SOURCE: Fararu — IRGC Naval Dare		
اگر تردید دارید، به تنگه هرمز نزدیک شوید!		
Literal: "If you have doubts, approach the Strait of Hormuz!"		
△ This is a dare/taunt in Persian register, not a warning. Swagger directed at enemy naval commanders. English outlets reported the substance but not the bravado – and the swagger is strategic communication to domestic audiences about IRGC confidence.		

confidence.

SOURCE: Javanonline – Kharg/Island Framing

جزایر ایرانی قتلگاه متجاوزان

Literal: "Iranian islands: the killing fields of aggressors."

▲ قتلگاه (qatlghāh) = slaughterhouse/killing field. Graphic martial framing being published in domestic Iranian press about Kharg, Abu Musa, and other islands. Psychological preparation of the domestic audience for casualties – the regime anticipates a ground assault and is pre-framing it as heroic defense.

SOURCE: Qalibaf, snn.ir – Legitimacy Ritual

شب‌های اتحاد مقدس

Literal: "Holy Alliance Nights"

▲ Does not appear in any English reporting. Refers to nighttime mobilization/allegiance events where hardliners publicly pledge bayat (oath of loyalty) to Mojtaba Khamenei. The regime is building a legitimacy ritual around a figure who lacks theological legitimacy – using mobilization spectacle as a substitute for clerical authority.

07 ATLAS HANDOFF — UNRESOLVED INTELLIGENCE GAPS

6 OPEN GAPS

The following gaps represent the highest-value unresolved signals requiring upstream processing. Priority ordered by strategic consequence.

1 OMAN'S BACK-CHANNEL ROLE

Not a single source – English or Arabic – is covering Oman's active diplomatic position. Muscat is geographically and historically the natural mediator. Its silence is itself the signal. Forensic diplomatic tracking required.

2 YUAN / USDT TOLL PAYMENT FLOW ARCHITECTURE

Where are toll funds moving? IRGC front companies? Iranian central bank? This is a sanctions architecture story requiring forensic financial intelligence – not geopolitical reporting. No outlet has followed the downstream architecture.

3 MOJTABA'S PHYSICAL LOCATION AND ABSENCE

If the Supreme Leader has not appeared publicly in 3 weeks of existential war, either he is being protected as an asset or he is being managed/controlled. IRGC-as-junta hypothesis requires confirmation. Track physical location signal.

4 ASSEMBLY OF EXPERTS DISSENTERS – IDENTITY MAPPING

Names and positions of members who resisted IRGC pressure in the succession vote. These individuals represent the last institutional resistance nodes to IRGC political capture. Identifying them informs probability of internal regime fracture.

5 HOUTHI BAB EL-MANDEB TRIGGER CONDITIONS

Houthis opened a "new front" on March 29 but have not imposed a full blockade. What is the specific trigger condition for full closure? Iranian island attack? Kharg ground assault? This is the most consequential open question for global energy markets.

6 IRANIAN PROTEST LEADERSHIP STRUCTURE

The "largest protests since 1979" have no visible named leadership in any source. Either deliberately decentralized (flash protest model) or suppressed in reporting. Either answer has major strategic implications for regime stability forecasting.